moment of greatness pass. Instead, to the surprise of many, the nobles of Kabul were not unwelcoming. The Rev. G. R. Gleig was not alone in imagining that the Afghans showed ‘a good deal of personal liking’ for individual British officers, though he quoted one chief who told him: ‘We wish that you had come among us as friends, and not as enemies, for you are fine fellows one by one, though as a body we hate you.’[36]

It helped that Dost Mohammad had ruled with an iron rod and imposed unusually heavy taxes on his people, as well as confiscating many estates to help finance his projects of jihad. This made the beginning of Shah Shuja’s rule seem relatively mild, and initially many Kabulis and most of the Durrani elite appear to have been willing to give their restored ruler the benefit of the doubt. As Mirza ‘Ata put it, ‘In the first months of their occupation of Kabul, the English brought most of the chiefs and the city and its environs into submission and obedience: the very few who disobeyed were imprisoned and their forts and property confiscated by the Company government.’[37] Moreover, Macnaghten wisely opted for a generous political settlement. Prominent Durrani nobles in the south were bought off, while the Ghilzai chiefs in the east were heavily subsidised, as were the ‘ulema. It was a massive drain on the Indian exchequer, and it quickly became clear that occupying Afghanistan was not going to be cheap; but the strategy succeeded in keeping the peace for the first autumn and winter of Shah Shuja’s reign.[38] As a result Auckland was able with some satisfaction to report to London, ‘The country is said to be quiet, the roads to be safe, commerce to be reviving, and the monarchy and change of government are still popular . . . Col. Roberts writes, “I have got acquainted with many of the chiefs. They are in general very desirous to be intimate with the *Sahib Loge*, and when I return to Kabul my house shall be open to them. They are happy to dine with us and to see us at their homes.”’[39]

This bright mood was only slightly dimmed by widespread scepticism as to whether the returning Barakzais would really accept Shuja’s olive branch and end the feud with the Sadozais that had now been carefully nourished for two generations. ‘Many of the Sadozai nobles found Shuja’s policy of reconciliation unpalatable,’ reported Mohammad Husain Herati. ‘They grumbled to each other while travelling or at court, saying: “Now that this clan of Barakzais is so highly respected, restored to all their old privileges and positions, it will not be long before the evil flames of discord rise high. How do these English, with all their claims to science and rationality and